

How Mark Villar Build his Tower of Political Victory

As the race for the 2022 Philippine National and Local Elections is on its final lap, 12 new legislators of the Upper House of Philippine Congress will serve, preserve, and forward the interests of the Filipino nation in the next six years. Mark Villar, the son of incumbent Senator Cynthia Villar and the country's wealthiest man Manny Villar, have consistently been part of the magic 12 senators Filipinos preferred based on various "nationally-representative" surveys run by private institutions in the Philippines. In a report published by Pulse Asia Survey in September 2021, the former Department of Public Works and Highways (DPWH) Secretary ranked 9th-10th as the senatorial bet of Filipinos (Aguilar, 2021). Outgoing President Rodrigo Duterte has also expressed his absolute support for the senatorial bid of Mark Villar citing that Villar earned the reputation of an efficient government worker manifested through his immaculate work in the DPWH (Parrocha & Gita-Carlos, 2022). Consequently, it was unexpected that Villar was named as the top senatorial bet in the RP-Mission and Development Foundation (RPMD) senatorial preference survey of 10,000 Filipinos last April 27, 2022 (Cabanban, 2022; BusinessMirror, 2022). Despite the qualms of social media consumers on the veracity and credibility of these surveys, one thing is certain: Mark Villar has done well in getting Filipinos to consider, if not include him in their magic 12. In this paper, we will look into the political strategies his campaign team employed from a social-psychological standpoint. We will identify which of these tactics backfired and catapulted him on his looming political victory.

The election paraphernalia disseminated by Villar's team follow a *central route to persuasion* – direct, logical, and objective messages are used. When you visit his social media accounts, particularly his Facebook Page (<https://www.facebook.com/SecMarkVillar>), he *presents the message as education* to netizens. Majority of the content displays his past works and accomplishments as the secretary of DPWH. The use of before-after photos (see Figure 1 below) of bridges, roads, and tunnels they built earned him the respect and admiration from netizens coming from different walks of life. Aside from compare and contrast images, his poster (see Figure 2 below) presents seat-falling numbers and data of his accomplishments in different areas like job-generation, classroom facilities, and disaster-prevention structures. In my view, this bombardment of data or "receipts" in layman's terms, have earned him a good baseline rank in surveys. Not only did he employ a central route to persuasion because his daily posts of pictures with huge names in the show business like Toni Gonzaga and political scene such as the outgoing President Duterte exhibits a *peripheral route to persuasion* wherein the *likeability* and *authority* of both persons to the wider society have benefitted him to be considered by the electorate. As a matter of fact, President Duterte's official *endorsement* as senator and *testimony* of hard work and diligence of Villar as DPWH secretary towards the end of the campaign trail have catapulted Villar to be the top choice of Filipinos in RPMD survey (Aguilar, 2022). The same thing is true when Villar was featured in Toni Gonzaga's YouTube program, Toni Talks (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fp0xZoFyVHI>). The multimedia star and self-confessed BBM-SARA supporter gave Villar the opportunity to present himself nakedly. In full honesty, he responded to every question about his integrity, triumphs, and challenges he overcame over the years as a parent, husband, and government employee. The borderline 4

million views, 47k likes, and positive comments as of this writing explain how his *honesty* and being vulnerable on screen have gained him support from netizens. In other words, the likability through his associations with influential people, authority evidenced by his government work and other positions held, and honesty as well as sincerity in interviews afforded him the *trust* and support of the people both online and offline.

The traditional politician tactics and populist energy Mark Villar exude have made him charming and saleable to the largest voting populace in terms of socioeconomic status, namely people belonging in the social class C (working class), D (working poor), and E (disadvantaged poor). In the latest Pulse Asia Survey report, Villar could place in the lowest at 7th and highest at 3rd senator with the most votes (March 2022 Nationwide Survey on the May 2022 Elections – Pulse Asia Research Inc., 2022). The respondents of this March 2022 survey are composed of above -mentioned social classes with the working class accounting for half of the total number of respondents. People living under these circumstances have limited access to information whether from traditional or social media. Although he was able to make his presence on social media, he lacks the presence of the largest voting populace. What does this say about loopholes in the political campaign strategy of Mark Villar? Despite the impact of the name he carries, as well as the investment in traditional media advertisement as well as contemporary media avenues like vlogs guesting and exposure, his campaign would have been better if he conducted house to house campaigns even in the rich vote provinces in the Philippines alone. The opportunity for physical, face-to-face interaction would benefit him greatly because people need a sense of contact of security and physical intimacy to feel represented and heard, especially in this end-of-the-world pandemic situation. This would have strengthened his position for securing the solo top senatorial spot against his rival people's champ and embattled Raffy Tulfo. Nevertheless, his appearance in BBM-Sara Uniteam people's rallies and local politicians' endorsements would narrow the disparity in impact due to his limited physical interaction with the social classes he is trying to win. Additionally, his 5-minute debut on Willie Revillame's Wowowin primetime show also contributed to inflating his appeal to these social classes (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8WDMhqXSRQ4>).

One of the biggest factors in Villar's impending political victory is his platform and purpose. Since his political career on a national scale gained traction by being one of the Duterte administration's cabinet secretaries, his platform revolves around the continuation of the "Build, Build, Build" agenda. One of the first political advertisements he released on television was a 1-minute video (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LYNeCgYlvx0>) elucidating how his public works and infrastructure projects helped improve the lives of ordinary Filipino citizens. To make it more appealing, the lyrics of the song are written in Tagalog and a farmer, construction worker, and student are the people delivering the lines. It is evident that Villar is appealing through his target audience by *evoking emotions of gratitude and joy* for the work he had done, and by extension how these people would feel change in their lives when he sits as senator. Furthermore, the dialogue of Villar and the chosen communicator enhances the effectiveness of the ad to persuade people to vote for him. For one, the use of these characters helped establish a shared identity with its audience. They are *social proof* of life's adversities. For once in our lives, we met, conversed, and supported farmers, laborers, and students who

have suffered in poverty and have been deprived of opportunities for economic development. Our shared experiences make Villar's ad more relatable to the public. Furthermore, Villar's opening statement in the political ad, "Para sayo, dapat may asenso ang buhay!" encapsulates his purpose for running. Aside from the fact that he is clearly targeting the social classes C, D, and E, the characters expounding on how he will achieve such is a brilliant move. The *discursive yet digestible message* of Villar on how he will continue transforming the lives of people at the infringes of the social pyramid makes him more palatable and at the edge of victory.

From what I have stipulated above, it cannot be denied that Villar packages himself as a competent candidate. He wants to establish his credibility and suitability for the job he is applying for through his accomplishments, endorsements, and testimonials from influential people in politics and media. Moreover, he portrays himself as the engineer of progress through the infrastructure projects and development plans he will forward in the Upper House. Clearly, the build, build, build, agenda he associates with his name will construct the bridge on his way to the Senate.

We have seen how routes to persuasion, the message, the audience, and the branding a political candidate displays are interconnected processes. In order to persuade the electorate to support you, or believe in you at least, is determined by the social psychological mechanisms of persuasion you employ. Despite the clamor for better governance for our country, it seems like entrenched political elites and clans would dominate the Philippine political scene in this 2022 national and local election. As predicted in surveys, Mark Villar's senatorial success is about to happen.

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Appendix

Figure 1. Daily post of Sec. Mark Villar Before-after road construction



Figure 2. Mark Villar Election Poster

